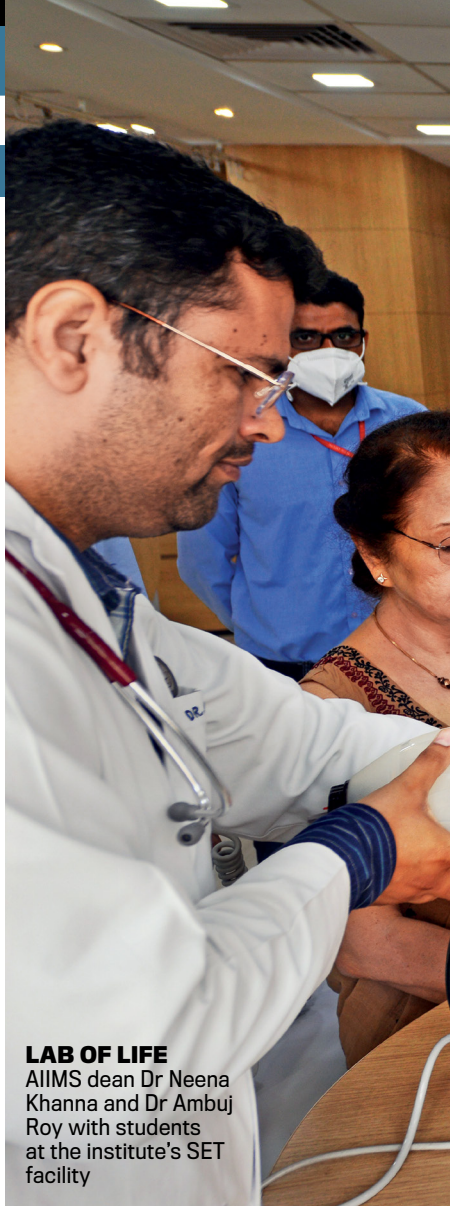
No. 1 ALL INDIA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES (AIIMS), NEW DELHI

A Perfect Prescription

NEITHER THE PANDEMIC NOR THE LOCKDOWNS CAME IN THE WAY OF THE INSTITUTE'S UNWAVERING COMMITMENT TO ITS PRINCIPLES

By Sonali Acharjee



LAB OF LIFE AIIMS dean Dr Neena Khanna and Dr Ambuj Roy with students at the institute's SET facility

The glass partition behind which Dr Randeep Guleria, director of the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, sits is a subtle but grim reminder of the vital role the institute played in helping India battle the scourge of Covid. That effort filtered into the academic space too as the institute focused on those within the campus, training 33,000 employees, students and staff on Covid management and infection control. Those students and faculty who were interested in Covid research were given seed money to start their work, the outcome of which was more than 900 peer-reviewed Covid publications from AIIMS.

The nation's premier government facility also set up 1,700 beds to treat close to 1,000 patients a day during the peak of the brutal second wave in April 2021. Support was given to the government to increase RT-PCR testing in the country, and the faculty at AIIMS mentored institutes with data and technical assistance so that a record 2 million tests could be done a day by the middle of last year. Learning from their experience of treating Covid patients, the students and staff put together these lessons in several webinars, conducted in partnership with the Union ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW). Some of these webinars were also held for SAARC nations in collaboration with the external affairs ministry. AIIMS also mentored around 550 hospitals in the country through its e-ICU so that Covid treatment could be streamlined and doctors kept abreast of the latest drugs and their efficacy.

It is this commitment to excellence in the face of the toughest of challenges that makes AIIMS the first choice of medical aspirants in the country despite the fact that India has over 600 medical colleges. It remains unparalleled in offering medical research